

2+

ADD-ON —

Oct 1 & 2. Requested by the group. Best on the second day; or run Session 2 at its 60-minute cut and use the last half hour for the 30-minute version.

GitHub 101: Saving, Sharing, and Undoing Your Work

5 · 30 · 10

GOAL —

Participants leave with a GitHub account, one private repository holding something real from this course, and the four words that make the rest of GitHub readable: repository, commit, branch, pull request. They also know the three things never to push: keys, sensitive data, and anything they have no right to share.

WHY —

The group asked for it, and the rest of the term runs through it. Session 3's scripts need a home with a history. Session 4's agents propose changes as diffs, and GitHub is where you read a diff before you accept it. Session 5's skill docs are shared as repositories. And a thesis with a clean repository is most of the way to a replication package.

READY-MADE MATERIALS —

Use these when nobody has their own. Everything here is public or was written for this course.

Note to send tonight

Tomorrow we'll spend 45 minutes on GitHub. Before we start, please make a free account at github.com with your personal email, verify the email, and turn on two-factor authentication when it asks. No installs needed; we'll work in the browser. If you already have an account, check that you can sign in.

Demo repository

github.com/jblakeslee89/llm-revealed-preferences. Public. 74 commits, each with a one-line reason and a Co-Authored-By line naming the model. A `.gitignore` that keeps copyrighted PDFs (`literature/`) and the key file (`.env`) off GitHub, and a `.env.example` showing where a key goes without containing one.

Practice repository

Name: `ai-group-notes`. Private. Tick "Add a README file." First file: `prompts.md`, holding one before/after prompt pair from Session 1. Session 3's scripts go in the same repository in two weeks.

Starter README

```
# ai-group-notes

What this is: my notes and working files from the RAND AI Facilitation Group, fall 2026.
What's here:
- prompts.md: before/after prompt pairs (Session 1)
- scripts/: analysis scripts written with the model (Session 3)
- skills/: my skill docs (Session 5)
What's not here: any RAND project data, keys, or copyrighted readings.
```

Starter .gitignore for research work

```
# keys and settings
.env
# data and readings stay local
data/raw/
literature/
*.pdf
# clutter
.DS_Store
__pycache__/_
~$*
```

Good and bad commit messages

Bad: update , fixes , asdf . Good: Drop 2019 rows counted twice in the merge , Add Session 1 prompt pair on the GAO summary . One line, starts with a verb, says what changed and, if it isn't obvious, why.

Git-tutor prompt

I'm new to Git and GitHub. Here is exactly what I did and the error I got: [paste]. Explain what happened in plain language, then give me the smallest safe fix. Do not suggest force-push, reset --hard, or deleting the repository.

Something to break on purpose

In the practice repository, edit the same line of the README on two branches, then try to merge both. GitHub shows a merge conflict and a web editor to resolve it. Better to meet one here than in a thesis chapter.

Plan 45 MINUTES

5 MIN COLD OPEN

Open the demo repository (the repository tab, not your dashboard). Click the commit count: 74 saved versions, each with a sentence saying what changed. Every one is a version you can return to and a record of how the analysis got here. Open one commit and point at the Co-Authored-By line naming the model: Session 1's attribution rule, recorded automatically on every change.

30

MIN

CORE

1 Four words 5

Git is the program that keeps the history; GitHub is the website that hosts it and adds the collaboration. Then the four words, each shown on the demo repository as you name it. **Repository:** a project folder with its full history. **Commit:** a saved version with a one-line reason. **Branch:** a parallel draft of the whole project. **Pull request:** a proposal to fold a branch back in, with the changes laid out for review.

2 The tour 8

On the demo repository: the README renders as the front page. Click one commit and read the diff: red lines removed, green lines added. Open a single file and click History. Open `.gitignore` and show `.env` and `literature/`: the key and the copyrighted PDFs stay on the laptop. Open `.env.example`: where a key goes, without the key. Finally press `.` on the keyboard; the whole repository opens in an editor in the browser.

3 Everyone does it 12

Browser only, nothing to install. Create the private practice repository with a README. Add `prompts.md` with a Session 1 prompt pair and commit it with a message that says why. Then edit the README, choose "Create a new branch," open a pull request to yourself, read the diff, and merge. Breakout rooms of three; whoever finishes first shares their screen for whoever is stuck.

4 Where the model fits 5

Run the Git-tutor prompt on a real error from step 3 if anyone produced one. Name the connection to the rest of the term: when an agent edits your files, a commit history turns every change into a diff you can read and a version you can restore. Mention that verified students get Copilot free through GitHub Education, and that what RAND's approved tool may connect to is a question for the policy, not for us.

10

MIN

DEBRIEF

Questions first; the facilitator briefing has answers to the likely ones. Then round the room: what would you put in a repository first? Start a "GitHub" section in the Playbook with the three never-push rules and anything that broke during step 3.

HOMEWORK

Put one real piece of work in a private repository: a thesis script, a lit-review table, your prompt pairs. Make three commits whose messages say why. Bring the mistake you made; Session 3's scripts go in the same place.

30

MIN CUT

FOR 30 MINUTES

Keep the cold open, the four words, and the tour (18 minutes), then questions. The hands-on block becomes homework, using the click path on the handout.

FACILITATOR
WATCH-OUTS

- Accounts take longer than you think: email verification, then two-factor setup. Send the note tonight. Anyone still without an account pairs with someone who has one.
 - Your GitHub home page and sidebar list your private repositories. Share a browser tab already open on the demo repository, never the home page.
 - Resist the terminal. Nobody needs rebase in week one. If someone asks, the briefing has six commands; offer them after the session.
 - Someone will ask whether RAND project code can live in a personal account. Answer from policy, not opinion. RAND has its own organization at github.com/RANDCorporation; the project lead decides. If the policy is unclear, log it as a question to raise upward.
 - Someone who knows Git well will want to go deep. Let them answer one question, then park the rest for after.
-